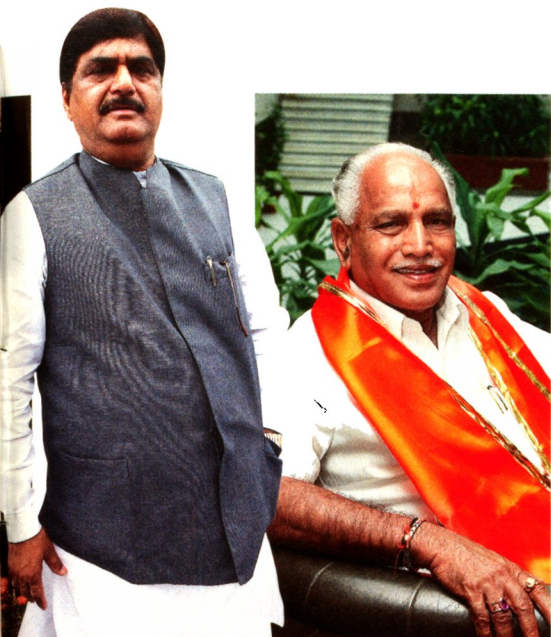




SIPRA DAS



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SIPRA DAS

AMIT KUMAR

NDA government sought to amend the Indian Patent Act in line with the international environment, the RSS bluntly told him that 60 of its MPs would oppose the Act. But when Vajpayee dared them to bring his government down by advancing the passage of the Bill, the RSS backed off. Yet, all through the Vajpayee regime and later, the RSS had periodically tried to reassert its authority. It forced Advani to quit after his infamous Jinnah remarks and when he tried to make Venkaiah Naidu his successor, the RSS stalled it and got Rajnath in to carry the RSS ideology forward with the help of GenNext leaders. The move backfired since the second rung leaders never accepted Rajnath's authority.

The gap between Advani and the RSS has only widened since and matters have reached a stage where the RSS is expected to review its relationship with the BJP at its *pratinidhi sabha* in July. RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, a non-interventionist so far, is likely to play a more proactive role. That leaves the RSS with two options: it can either wash its hands off the BJP or fully take over the party. A senior RSS leader said they would be very keen to restore to the BJP its original tag of "the party with a difference". How successful their mission is will be reflected in the choice of the BJP's next president. One thing though is certain: the BJP doesn't have much time to save itself from oblivion.

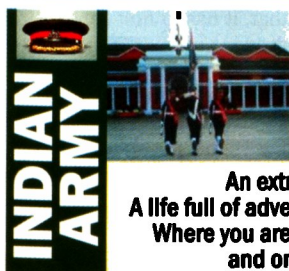
BUT THERE IS STILL HOPE

Notwithstanding the current crisis of identity and leadership, there is hope for the party. It still has solid vote-banks in most of the states and also boasts of powerful state leaders who can steer the party to victory in the next general elections. Those who are blaming the ideological confusion at the top for the electoral losses forget that the same party has trounced the Congress in Bihar, Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat and Jharkhand which accounted for over half of the 116 seats the party won.

These states have leaders who are committed to



The BJP is still blessed with an array of leaders who, given a meaningful role, can turn the party's fortunes around.



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